

PTI PHOTO

HASINA WITH SONIA GANDHI
AT HER RESIDENCE; MANMOHAN
SINGH WELCOMES HER AT
RASHTRAPATI BHAVAN (RIGHT)



Eastern ENTENTE

Hasina's visit brought a turnaround in bilateral ties with a key agreement on tackling terrorism which may address India's long-standing security concerns

| By Saurabh Shukla |

State visits are usually dull and boring with a dash of ceremony, banquet and some ritualistic joint statements thrown in as deliverables. But the new year seems to have begun on a good note for Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and his foreign policy team as there are signs of a breakthrough on the eastern frontier with a pivotal visit of the Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina on January 11.

Hasina's trip to New Delhi was simply not about nostalgia but had considerable substance rolled up in a package from Dhaka. Bangladesh promised to address India's long-

standing security concerns and New Delhi more than made up by providing a \$1-billion (Rs 4,500 crore) line of credit, the single highest amount of concessional credit it has ever given to any country. This aid will go a long way in developing infrastructure in the neighbouring country, especially its railways. The line of credit was an attempt to reach out to the people of Bangladesh, who have till now faced vicious anti-India rhetoric during the previous Khaleda Zia regime.

The two sides have also agreed to work on an early border agreement, which has been a flashpoint with frequent clashes between the border guarding forces of the two countries. While Hasina told Manmohan that she

will not allow her country's territory to be used for anti-India activities, the two agreed that terrorism was a common threat. With a 4,096-km-long border and a slew of contentious issues like security, trade, transit and water, Bangladesh fares high on India's must-resolve list. A friendly government in Dhaka is pivotal for India's security interests since only 800 km of the border has been fenced so far and many anti-India groups have taken shelter in that country. Also, Pakistan's intelligence agency ISI is using the open border to mount terror attacks in India. Says External Affairs Minister S.M. Krishna: "The visit has set in motion a new architecture of strategic ties between